Creating Community-Driven Innovation

Speakers: Dr. Dino Beckett, Williamson Health & Wellness and Daryn Dodson, Impact Investor
Interviewer: Randall Ussery, Free Range and Babson Faculty Member
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Transcript:

Lynn Santropietro: Hi, I'm Lynn Santopietro. I'm the director of Babson College in San Francisco and I'm so happy you're here for our THRIVE series. This is our June event, we do these monthly. Tonight, we have two special guests, two social innovators who are going to have a conversation tonight about healthcare, which I think is incredibly timely. We have Dr. Beckett and Daryn Dodson, and the conversation is facilitated by Randall Ussery. Randall is the CEO of Free Range, which is our partner in this series, and Randall's also an alum as well as a faculty member here. So thank you all for joining us, thrilled to have you.

Dino Beckett: Thank you.

Daryn Dodson: Thanks.

Randall Ussery: Thanks for coming. I typically don't use notes, but since you're here, Daryn, I'm going to use notes. I thought I'd start this out by kind of bringing up a book a little bit. This happens to be a children's book, it's called *A is for Activist*. It's by Innosanto Nagara, but every time I pick it up and read it to my wonderful little child, I think of Daryn and I'm going to start with A.

"A is for activist, advocate, abolitionist, ally, actively answering a call to action."

I like to add a little piece for you, and acting as a force of good in business. Daryn, thanks for being here.

Daryn Dodson: Thanks.

Randall Ussery: Yeah, you can ... He deserves it.

Daryn Dodson: Thank you.

Randall Ussery: And then for Dr. Beckett, I thought I would start with I.

"I is for inspiration, inventing a new way of doing things, leveraging insights from abroad, and ignoring any negative hurdles that may stand in the way of an invitation one day."

And I think ... The reason why I bring that up is when I think of these guys, I really think about how I can become a better activist, how I can dream bigger, and do some of the stuff that they're doing. So I thought we'd just begin, Daryn, like tell us a little bit about you. Give us your personal journey.

Daryn Dodson: Sure. I grew up in Washington DC, a city that I'm really passionate about. And one of the things about Washington DC is it's one of the most unequal cities in the country by the Gini coefficient, so I grew up understanding what that meant in a variety of different ways. I grew up knowing all four of my grandparents, which was a powerful experience to be connected to another generation and through my grandmother to another century, who lived through the Great Depression. So the issues of equity and injustice in many ways were present in the city of Washington.

I spent a lot of time starting little businesses, like bagel businesses in my high school, which inspired me about the power of entrepreneurship. And then spent a lot of time also working on issues with social justice, working with some local programs, got trained as a person that focused on religious and racial tolerance. And then chose to go to Duke University after finishing high school because of some of the challenges on campus around racial justice. I think a African American student was arrested for riding his own bike around the time I was writing my application. And an incredible place to explore academic and cultural, kind of understanding the south and kind of unlock the imagination from an academic standpoint, but also a place to exercise activism in the campus.

We had lots of gatherings between all white fraternities and African American fraternities, sororities, talking about some of the challenges that we were facing collectively and working together to have really, really difficult and hard conversations. So the themes of social justice and entrepreneurship have run

through my life in many different ways. I spent some time in the subprime lending crisis trying to help low income folks protect themselves from predatory loans and regulated banks. And then also eventually going to business school, working with Hurricane Katrina after Hurricane Katrina in New Orleans, and then ultimately to a career in impact investing where I am now in community and economic development and that's how I met this wonderful, wonderful person, Dr. Beckett.

Randall Ussery: And you sit on a few boards.

Daryn Dodson: Also I have the privilege of serving on the Ben & Jerry's Board of Directors, also very, very focused on social justice and that's been an incredible experience and lots of fun as well.

Randall Ussery: Great. All right, do you want to tell us a little bit about you?

Dino Beckett: Sure. So, Dino Beckett. I grew up in Williamson, West Virginia, where I'm at now, and growing up in a small town with core community values where faith and family were big things that kept everyone together. When I grew up, my parents always talked about how what a wonderful place this town was, Williamson, and how it'd gone through this whole economic up and down. And for me, growing up there and having aunts, uncles, cousins around, that really formed a lot of what I thought about the community that I lived in.

I also had a business that I started in my early entrepreneurial days. I sold pencils at my school, which was the first venture that I'd gone into. That's what I was talking earlier about how my aunt had this whole collection of pencils that were sitting around and she didn't know what to do with them, so I started selling them at the school to make some extra money, which was great, but then I was shut down by the principal after he put in his pencil machine. So then I learned how the regulatory component kicked in and then I learned how to go black market with my pencils.

So early on, I wanted to be part of the entrepreneurial culture and didn't realize that that was how I was pursuing things in life. I went to West Virginia University and after graduating, I ended up going to South America to study, to do an internship in Chile to look at how physicians worked in a very rural community and how that experience really inspired me to become a physician because of this basic understanding of how they did not have diagnostic tools or imaging,

they were using their hands, their ears, their eyes and just laying hands on people. And that had a profound impact on me to what I wanted to do and then I wanted to take that back to my community.

So after I returned from South America, I ended up working as chemist, a little diversion there, which was not so exciting for me, but then I ended up following my true love of wanting to become a physician. And so as I went through, I always had this feeling that I would be back in Williamson and, I mean, I had the opportunity of taking care of some of the greatest people in the world and I feel very strongly about how growing up in Williamson impacted my life and it was a way for me to give back to the community. But for me, looking at how now we can take medicine and health and tie that to economic development has been a really big push of what I've been doing in probably the last seven years.

I did have the opportunity of meeting Daryn and got experience, some of the amazing stuff that was going on in New Orleans post-Katrina and that was a very inspirational time for me to see how that was happening and how that could be something to bring back to my community as well. So having that experience and just really admiring somebody and how so much hard work and innovation goes into a place and creates change, I really wanted to kind of bring that, like I said, back to Williamson.

[00:08:55]

Randall Ussery: Yeah. And before we finish with the personal journey, maybe speak a little bit about New Orleans and just what went down there.

Daryn Dodson: Sure. I think when we think about kind of big problems, one of the things that I don't like to separate from a philosophical standpoint is economics from justice. I think a lot of people like to have conversations about justice, but then they don't talk about economics, and a lot of people like to have conversations about economics, but don't talk about justice. And I think New Orleans is a great example of a nationwide discussion that was forced where lots of people were talking about each of those, but being in business school at the time and having a conversation with a lot of my classmates, we'd often approach the problems from different angles based on our life experiences.

So part of what I felt was sort of necessary at the time was, for people that were very far away having a discussion in the bubble of Silicon Valley around something that was happening in a community that was a thousand or more miles away, was that we should be informed by real people that lived there.

So part of what we did is we put together a team and went to New Orleans in the spirit of service and we tried to help out, initially, by helping a family rebuild their house, which was actually incredibly challenging for MBA students to do, who had almost no experience in putting together a house. And I remember hitting a gas pipe in the house and thank God nothing happened, but you could tell how bad of an idea it was by having inexperience. I remember spending all this time and energy, but ultimately coming back saying, "Well, is there another way that we could help?"

Randall Ussery: And this was post-Katrina, right?

Daryn Dodson: This is post-Katrina. So the following year, we created a program that would 18So whether it was coastal restoration, or whether it was looking at ways to create gumbo to sell all around the country, or whether it was thinking about educating Google employees about how their AdWords tools would fit to the culture of innovation in local communities and sort of the service economy within New Orleans and tourism. There was lots of different things to explore and learn from.

So the big insight there was the business school students that were around the country that didn't know much about running companies, 'cause they're going to business school to be risk averse, would have the chance to sit with entrepreneurs, feel what it feels like in their stomach to take a risk in the context of one of the hardest problems in the country. Maybe help out by giving some strategic advice, but learn and solve this critical problem that they were facing. And the students would work really hard and then often make connections that would help the entrepreneurs to grow.

So that was the concept that culminated in a hundred thousand hours of time from volunteers that actually paid to be a part of the learning process of the community there in New Orleans and help recreate the infrastructure for entrepreneurship and innovation.

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Randall Ussery: And it still continues today.

Daryn Dodson: And it still continues today. We just had about 18,000 people plugged in in New Orleans this year, celebrating across 90 different stages of entrepreneurship and innovation the cultural context. And one of the things that is most meaningful to me about that experience is, yes, it's great to see lots of people out for a week in New Orleans and a street shut down, but what now is happening is that as kids are looking at opportunities of what they want to be, entrepreneurship is part of the vernacular. And my favorite event is called The Big Idea and basically, there are 30 entrepreneurs that are presenting their own idea and little kids are going up and down and listening to the pitches and they all have little chips that are worth about $100 each and they ultimately decide which entrepreneur to invest in.

So you have third graders making angel investment decisions and trying to think about what it's like not only to be an entrepreneur, but to be an investor and evaluate pitches, so it becomes a part of the culture. And all this is happening within the culture of jazz, instruments are playing in the background, you got the crawfish going and people are eating and having fun, but it's a cultural fit in the way that we're talking about entrepreneurship and innovation.

[00:14:36]

Randall Ussery: Yeah. What's really interesting about that is Dino was kind of doing the same thing in West Virginia, right?

Daryn Dodson: That's right.

Randall Ussery: So that's a good segue into West Virginia. I thought I'd share some stats just to kind of compare West Virginia as a whole to San Francisco:

	West Virginia	San Francisco
Population:	1.8 million	870,000
Per Square Mile:	77.4 people	17,000 people
Per Capita Income:	$24,000	~$52,000
Bachelor’s degree:	~20%	~52%

You want to share some stats from a health perspective?

Dino Beckett: Sure. So when you look at West Virginia, we're usually one, two, or three in many categories such as hypertension, obesity, diabetes. And then when you drill down into Mingo County, we're usually either one, two, or three in those same categories. So you have a lot of health disparities that are impacting what's happening within a community as well. So you look at that, you look at we have over 40% of children under the age of four that live poverty. You have our diabetes rate. Right now, we're at I think 11% in Mingo County, the state is probably 14%.

So what happens when you have these chronic disease states and how that impacts not only health, but also it impacts an economy as well because you're having to utilize a lot of your earning to go towards healthcare, but the state spend on healthcare is also very big to where you're taking resources that could be used for other things. And we know that entrepreneurism and poverty are inversely related, so if we can address the issues of health and entrepreneurship that we can work in a lot of ways to impact poverty as well.

Randall Ussery: Could you define health for us?

Dino Beckett: Yeah. Health for me is ... Being a doctor, we have a very specific belief of health, but my belief of health is that it actually looks at what's somebody's living conditions. Do they have livable wages? Do they have access to fresh food? Do they have, obviously, the traditional thought process of health, but all these other factors that are playing a big role in what's going on in that person's life.

Randall Ussery: Yeah, it makes up economics injustice, right?

Dino Beckett: Right.

[00:17:10]

Randall Ussery: Yeah. Maybe just give the audience a little bit about Williamson Health Initiative, how it began and where it is today.

Dino Beckett: Yeah. So Williamson Health and Wellness is the non-profit that I'm the CEO of and it actually started in my office. I have my own practice as a private physician, but we started on Good Friday in 2011. We started noticing that there were lots of people that lost jobs, didn't have insurance, unemployed, various reasons, in

between jobs, so they didn't have access or the ability to pay for healthcare. So we started this clinic, a free clinic so to speak, in my office and that was Good Friday 2011. And we started doing a lot of things tying in other services that could benefit people as well and I happened to meet a lady by the name of Monica Niess who was a grant writer and she was like, "You really need to pursue looking at a federally qualified health center." And I had no idea what that meant, but it's a clinic that basically receives funding from the government, but you also generate revenue as well.

So I had to learn this whole process and, fortunately, she was able to help with a lot of the learning curve with what we were doing. And we had put together a board and created this outstanding community, bringing all the stakeholders together to look at what possibly we could do. Then short after, that's when I met Daryn. But so Williamson Health and Wellness as an idea of creating access to healthcare, but then it grew into this whole project where not only is healthcare at the forefront in the way that we look at health, but also looking at how we can economically become an economic driver within the community as well.

Randall Ussery: Yeah, and I've been fortunate to spend some time with you there and we think innovation is happening here every day and when you get there, you really see innovation on the ground happening. And congratulations, you were named Rural Healthcare Doctor of the Year this year, which is a fairly impressive statement by any organization, particularly RWJ, so congratulations on that.

[00:19:20] From an innovation perspective, Daryn, what are you seeing on the ground in West Virginia?

Daryn Dodson: Well, I think part of the way that we've engaged with West Virginia over the years and we have some of our team members in the audiences through impact experience. And one of the core beliefs of impact experience is that we believe in the wisdom of people that live in communities and their ability to solve problems that, if they solve there, are relevant to communities around the world. And when we showed up in Williamson, it was part of the reason why we believed that that is true. I mean, I think that was an experience and a belief, but we saw it proved out in Williamson. And the ability to create, in particular, and Dr. Beckett can share more about it, but a drop in A1C, hemoglobin A1C that is on parallel with a billion dollar blockbuster drug through innovation and process around highly

trained healthcare workers or community health workers was something really powerful.

But I think the insights and the training, not only from a medical standpoint, but also from a cultural relevance standpoint, are what kind of blow people away. And I know there are a lot of doctors at very elite universities around the country that are struggling to come up with similar models to reduce A1C in rural communities in similar ways. And what surprises me the most is how rarely they show up in communities that have been able to achieve this to understand how they're achieving this, which I think is kind of a blind spot for leading universities in their paradigms of creating change.

So the surprising thing to me isn't that they came with their own solutions, but it's that the world's still asleep that rural communities with these great challenges have ... Asleep to fact that they've come up with their incredible solutions that are highly relevant and scalable, but are somewhat underappreciated.

Randall Ussery: Yeah, it comes back to that comment a little earlier where you think ... or you don't have very much context, so you think you can provide them context for how to be innovative, when really innovation is happening. What's really fascinating about the FQ, or federally qualified health centers, is it was actually founded in South Africa in the 60s, right, and then we adopted it here in the states. And it's slowly rolled out, but it's becoming more and more important to rural healthcare communities for sure.

[00:22:17] From a talent perspective, Daryn, maybe talk a little bit about Impact Experience and the model and how you actually leverage talent to solve some of these problems.

Daryn Dodson: Sure. So taking that belief that solutions spring from the communities themselves, part of what is missing is, particularly in the conversation between the bubble here in Silicon Valley and rural communities of which, I think, got increasingly polarized during the last election, and the veil between what's actually happening there and what people think is happening there actually grew and expanded. So part of what you hear in places like this on Stanford's campus or in campuses of Google or Facebook or other places is beliefs about West

Virginia, but also a belief about the future of technology and the idea that there's going to be these incredible disruptions of workforce.

But a lot of these disruptions are informed by the communities themselves and where they're at, so the idea is to get to know each other's humanity first and bring together people to test their ideas against reality, which I think is highly relevant to companies, but put them in situations where they're actually trying to solve problems alongside people that are doing it within the context of Williamson. So we brought 30 people from around the country and around the world, innovators and entrepreneurs, to Williamson to work together alongside of the community to learn and then to roll up their sleeves and begin to work and make commitments towards moving some of these challenges along, and that's essentially the model

But I can't stress enough, a lot of times within investment strategies, people invest from far away and expect good things to happen without building trust first. So we mentioned that we've known each other for over five years now and there's a process of building trust that we think is really important and one of the priorities of the gatherings when we get together, we also move into design thinking and then commitments and solutions and things of that sort, but I think that's the most missed point in community development.

[00:24:53] When we were spending time in New Orleans before an MBA team ... After we did it for three years and we kind of messed it up for two years, we decided to make sure we built context and we asked people to humbly walk into communities and imagine in their minds that communities could add value before they started telling people what to do. And the results drastically changed in terms of people's overall experience and, actually, the acceleration of different ventures became possible. But the natural tendency is to walk in and start telling people what to do and, lo and behold, some of the best answers to our biggest challenges are lying dormant in communities like Williamson without coming humbly to the communities.

Randall Ussery: Yeah. So, Dino, on that end, we've gotten to spend quite a bit of time together and I think you have an incredible vision or you've packed an incredible vision for Williamson. What is that vision, like where do you see Williamson 2.0?

Dino Beckett: Well, the biggest thing is we've been a coal based economy for many years and that's a way of people providing for their family, so it's a way they fed their families, they provided education for them. So when you have people that have a high school degree or maybe don't have a high school degree, they can go into a coal mine and making $80,000 to $120,000 a year and then once you start losing those jobs, that's a very big impact. So we have to look at how to diversify the economy and look at other ways of ... It's not like there's going to be these factories dropping in to Williamson to replace what's been lost, so having the ability to look at what are the assets that we have, which are many, and then how can we leverage those and accelerate ideas with people in the community, as well as bringing in outside people as well.

But there are things that we look at as far as tourism, just the amount of talent that's there from a workforce, also the culture, the arts, all these things that are just greatly overlooked that could be brought into the forefront in helping us change the economy, to diversify it more. Coal will always have some form in West Virginia, particularly in Mingo County, but it's taken a much smaller role, so it allows us to look at ways that we can start filling that void with other opportunities and that's kind of where we're going with that.

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Randall Ussery: Yeah. And if you think about it from ... Just to stick with some of the themes, like we've talked about innovation bringing best practice and leveraging the best practice that's already happening on the ground. We're talking about access to talent or leveraging the talent that already exists on the ground. The other kind of key component is capital, right, and not just any type of capital, long term capital that's going to really see this community through.

Daryn, you've been investing in companies for a very long time, you're very familiar on the long term capital plays that are necessary to think about driving communities in any way. What, from a capital perspective, do you think is needed in West Virginia and what are the opportunities from a capital perspective, or an investment perspective?

Daryn Dodson: No, I think it's a great question. So part of my background is investing in the leading private equity funds in the world in the sector called impact investing. And

some of the leading private equity funds in the world are just impact investments period, which I also find fascinating 'cause a lot of people will think that just 'cause it's impact investing, they don't generate returns. So what I would say is that in terms of growth and impact investing, there's been explosive growth in the field. There are 95 funds that were created in the last four years. This is just within impact private equity and the amount of capital has moved from about $2 billion to $13.4 billion over the last several years as well.

So there's a huge upward trend and what I see is that capital doesn't get to communities like Williamson to fund the innovation and creates a big gap. So part of what our challenge is at impact experience -- and two of my colleagues, Summer and Nelson, are in the audience, speaking of talent. Woo! And Jenna's overseas now from our team as well -- but it's an incredible opportunity to kind of fill this gap.

So one is, impact investors, as much as I love them and I'm a part of that community, after seven years of investing in 16 funds on five different continents, part of what I saw was that they're very distant from the problems that they're trying to solve. And there's an incredible opportunity to learn about the problems that they're trying to solve by visiting communities like Williamson and working together with them to roll up their sleeves and work on the problems together. And then thoughtfully think about relationship and other aspects of funding actual ventures in communities over time and leverage the right type of capital to move things forward and fund innovation.

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Randall Ussery: And to make sure that capital stays in those communities. That's the tough one.

Daryn Dodson: That's a great point and we can talk about the history of extraction and how the concept of capital staying in communities is a reverse of that idea. So I think that's a really important piece of it. I don't know ... I think the models of impact investing that have been developed so far, and there are some great groups that are working super hard on non-extractive impact investing, but I think we have a long way to go in figuring that out, but it's a really good point.

But I do think that there is a really important obligation for this field and opportunity for the field to really get to the source of the root causes of problems by understanding intimately how to build solutions together.

Randall Ussery: And monetize those solutions and make a decent living.

Daryn Dodson: And monetize those solutions.

Randall Ussery: Yeah.

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Daryn Dodson: It sounds crazy that ... I mean, some of it ... I'm just thinking about the value of some of the solutions that are being created, especially as our country goes into huge challenges about how to get together as a country and how to speak to each other as a country. And Williamson's modeling solutions a micro level within their community that can be replicable in lots of other places. But then again, as they're moving beyond the challenges of extractive histories in the different narratives that they're working on, there are lots of larger cities that are working on similar problems. So getting there to really understand is part of the challenge.

[00:32:30] Williamson Community Health Model

Randall Ussery: And if you just take a drive with Dino for a day around Mingo County, you'll be like, "Oh, there's an opportunity. I'm going to pick that one up. Oh, there's an opportunity," and it's worth moving there and investing in the community, particularly if you're looking for somewhere to be for a very long time.

On that end, I mean, where are seeing the investments and where capital is needed?

Dino Beckett: Well, I mean, the model that we use within our clinic, like the one specific program that we have where we've taken community health workers and used that on the healthcare front to look at high risk patients. These are people that utilize a lot of healthcare dollars and poorly because they've not learned their disease state and how to take care of it. So by utilizing the community health workers, what we've been able to do is what Daryn alluded to, by using education, just the face to face meeting with them and continuity with patients, we've been able to drop hemoglobin A1C, which is a three month measurement of someone's blood sugar. We've been able to drop that by 2.2%.

So if you're a drug company and you create a drug that drops hemoglobin A1C by .6%, that's a multi million dollar drug. So we've been able to do that just kind of the old fashioned way with education, boots on the ground, and really looking at ways that are outside the box and having the patient as a key component of that healthcare team, actually the leader of that healthcare team.

Daryn Dodson: So you mean you didn't have to give them a bunch of pills? The old fashioned way is cheaper?

Dino Beckett: Yeah, much cheaper.

Daryn Dodson: Not a billion dollars in R&D?

Randall Ussery: And that particular model is currently being looked at replicating in other areas, right?

Dino Beckett: Yeah, it's a simple model that has such great impact now. It is getting some awareness and it is easily replicable to communities throughout the United States and the world.

Randall Ussery: Yeah. So we're going to head into Q&A in a little bit, but just before we end, what do you need? If you could have anything tomorrow in Williamson, how can we help as a group?

Dino Beckett: Well, I think the biggest thing is the awareness, which we're getting more of that. But how Daryn has eloquently stated how you have the people in Williamson that have or in Mingo County, West Virginia have these innovative ideas and problems that they're facing and how they're looking at them, but then bringing in capital and people with expertise to look at that and how to problem solve side by side. One, I think it's great to help address a problem, but also accelerates the solutions that we can come up with at a much more rapid pace.

Randall Ussery: Yeah, absolutely. So I'm going to open it up to the audience. Any questions? Yeah.

[00:35:00]

Speaker 6: Thank you for sharing those stories. It's more of a personal question. How do you stay motivated and who inspires you, like who do you look up to?

Dino Beckett: I think one of the biggest inspirations for me was my parents grew up in the area and, like I said, it is such a nice community and some of the greatest people in

the world. I mean, I can have the worst day and I go in and just have a patient thank me for just taking care of them or bringing me some fresh tomatoes that they've made. I mean, those are things that are inspirational to me from a standpoint that we're in this fight trying to do the thing that's good for a great group of people. So patients and family and just the ... I mean, West Virginia's a very resilient state. We've had many times been knocked down, but we keep standing back up.

So I think that that's part of it too, just being a little stubborn and I love being told no or I can't do something, that's how I actually got to med school. But that mountaineer spirit, I guess, of being able to carry that resilience on, so that definitely inspires me.

Daryn Dodson: Yeah. I think ... Well, I do, as our team spends a lot of time kind of checking in and building what I would call rituals and processes, routines, and habits in order to check in and see, did we run this morning, or did we meditate, or did we find a way to build resilience to the system that we're trying to change? Because what we realized is that one of the most powerful things that we can do as changes in a system is to create routines and processes among our team that are keeping us awake, as Martin Luther King would say, awake during the revolution.

And it's really hard to remember if you're in a culture that thinks that Williamson doesn't have good ideas, that thinks that they're people that voted differently than they did, so they shouldn't talk to them. And a prevailing sea change of this splitting apart of the fabric of a country in a world and to revive the idea that we're better together and we can build unity, diversity, and build innovation to get us out of the challenges that we're in as a country in a world, then you have to kind of think differently.

So we were talking within our team earlier today about the power of the news to limit your ability to notice awe and beauty. So we spent a little bit of time just articulating how we want to build our team getaways or whether we want to do retreats and things of that sort. And of course, we do a lot of incredibly rigorous work and it's not just all about sitting around and thinking about and navel-gazing and stuff like that, but if you aren't consciously ... Look, the way I see it is that there's a river of things that are flowing at all times that are keeping communities

like Williamson and other communities around the country, rural communities, and cities, and injustices in place.

So if we don't create a little eddy in the river to be able to think about the strategy to reverse or to ... We had a wonderful Jiu-Jitsu leader up here in one of the other THRIVE series, Sunwoo, who's also a great friend, runs a company called Sixup, but he's also a Judo champion. And part of the reason why it's so refreshing to convene with people like that is 'cause they're thinking about how to reverse the energy that's coming towards them to create a a new system and that's part of what I think is necessary.

So I think it's a really good question. We do actively think about that in the self care and the health. Like I said, it's part of the work, and if it's not part of the work, then people end up burning out really quickly and not able to revive. A good dancing every once in a while is really important and I think our team would say that too.

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Randall Ussery: And on the ground, there's a particular narrative that has been taking place over years that isn't actually defined by the community as well and it's often times defined by the national narrative of what is West Virginia like or how we think it may be, but yet we've never been there before. And so there's this moment of consciousness that's happening, particularly in Williamson right now and it's being led by Williamson Health and Wellness to kind of reframe the narrative and really rethink who we are going to be in the future, kind of 2.0, and let that be the guiding light versus, "All right, this is what Washington DC's saying about us right now." They're second to last in everything and how there's no opportunity.

After a while, you just get beat down, right. You're a kid, you're growing up there. That's how you perceive yourself, so there's this flipping of narrative that's happening and part of it is it's all about just boots on the ground, right. I mean, it's not going to happen any way, it's going to be getting to know your neighbor, right. It's going to be forming that trust.

[00:40:50]

Daryn Dodson: Yeah and I think in the Jiu-Jitsu or Judo kind of reversing of the energy that's coming towards Williamson, I think the narrative is super powerful. I would also say that we'd never do an impact experience convening without musicians and storytellers because the stories rest in the cultural assets of communities that are way undervalued relative to their ability to create change. There's some great people at the culture bank here in town that are coming up with different strategies to monetize community cultural assets. That is really neat stuff.

But I remember when I moved down to New Orleans, it took two years for me to move down there fully and I lived there for three years after I graduated from business school. And during the two years right after the storm, almost everyone I knew that moved back burned out. And right around the two year mark when I moved down, the music had come back and the ability to work 19 hours a day and then go out and listen to music that will revive your soul and revive your spirits and get back out and get to work for another 19 hours the next day was what really shifted ... In my opinion, when the musicians came back, that shifted the entire culture and unlocked people's ability to be refreshed and then go back to work.

And that's one of the things that I love about West Virginia is hearing ... We have a friend, Tim, who's an ethnomusicologist who brings out the story of the banjos and how they got to West Virginia. Some of their African roots connecting across cultures and creating this mean where people from very different backgrounds all of a sudden are suddenly closer in meeting the challenges that's put before them and sort of the broadest sense of what that means at a national or international level because they've been brought together through music, which is one of the great conveners of people.

[00:43:08]

Speaker 7: Hi, my name is Jocelyn Ryder. I'm an equality consultant and I'm especially interested in the ... Daryn, how you bring restorative justice and entrepreneurship together 'cause you talked about some of that. 'Cause one of the things I think about with entrepreneurship is learning how to win. And when I think about that in relation to restorative justice, I think of learning how to cooperate. So can you tell me something about how those things mesh for you and what you've seen?

Daryn Dodson: That's a really interesting kind of thought process. So what I will say, I'll share just a story of ... 'Cause to me, justice it about winning too, right, and it's just defined as ... The structural barriers that exist and what winning means is beating those structural barriers that are inside of a system. So I talked about the river that was flowing towards people of injustice and that river is flowing at kids that are in the education system. We see that African American kids are expelled at four times the rate of white kids for the same infraction in the education system. We can look at healthcare disparities and see similar outcomes, that there's less treatments regardless of class across race within healthcare and digging into those statistics.

But basically, I think one of the core concepts of winning in entrepreneurship is about talent and acquiring the best talent in the world, and this is something that Silicon Valley claims to be fierce about. But if we really wanted to find the best talent in the world, what we would do is make sure that every third grader in the country was being educated so that we could find the untapped genius in communities around the entire country and in communities throughout the world so that we could end up with the best workforce that would be the most competitive, create the best companies, solve the hardest problems in the world.

So to me, the system of injustice is preventing winning across the entire strategies of entrepreneurial companies. And again, it's one of those things that's amazing to me that people miss as they call themselves being hungry for talent and they look at the less than 1% minority makeup and way under weighted gender makeup of their companies and pretend like that is finding the best talent in the world. There's statistically ... You have incredibly data driven people that when it gets to this area, suddenly forget statistical analyses and how to find things that happen beyond chance. I can tell you it's not by chance that 1% of people are minorities within many of the tech companies that are within a couple blocks of here. It's by design, right, and unless we ask tough questions about that design and don't pretend like it just happened, then we'll never unlock the full potential of the companies that we're trying to build.

Speaker 7: Thank you.

Daryn Dodson: Sure.

[47:01]

Speaker 8: Hi, so you guys have talked about the need to provide good education and healthcare to people, especially young people, to provide opportunities for graduate students and entrepreneurs to get out into Appalachia, see what it's like down there. What about the talent pool that is kids who grew up in coal country and then moved away? How are you incentivizing them to return, since it's not always the most glamorous ... I'm from Raleigh, North Carolina, which is like a city. We don't have half the apps on my phone working out there, so I think about Mingo County and when I was there a decade ago, I didn't have cell phone service. So what's the draw, what's the appeal other than that inherit desire to give back to your community because you love it?

Dino Beckett: I think one thing is that Daryn has been very successful in having as part of the strategy is connecting the diaspora of West Virginia to ... and there's this collective spirit of people that have lived in West Virginia and Appalachia that even though they may be far away, they still have this connection to that and how that they can be a part of this West Virginia, Williamson 2.0, as we've called it. I think that that's really important 'cause, I mean, there are people that when they look at where they're living now, maybe the lifestyle's not what they were brought up in and, culturally, it's not the same as what they had, so if there is an opportunity to go back to that, and then we have infrastructure in place so you can get a cell signal, then that's going to help create the opportunity for people to come back.

But that's part of the strategy that we had to do is build out that infrastructure, those are things that we're looking at as well, but being able to show people opportunities because that's my thought is that I would love to grow our entrepreneurs, especially at a younger age, but also attract ... 'Cause the number one export for West Virginia is not coal, it's the talent of the people that are there, so that's why you have a population that has decreased. But West Virginians that have gone out into the world have made a huge impact. There's one guys that's been around California for a while that's created a couple of NBA championships by the name of Jerry West.

So I mean, you can see that we do have people to come out of that and there is that resilience, that just inherent nature to win, to be successful. So if they could

translate that opportunity back home and have those opportunities, I think that that's a way to attract them back as well.

Daryn Dodson: And your question was really, I think, awesome to me because it presents ... What you told was a story, right, you told the story of the person not wanting to go back because of the lost opportunities. But there's another story and that story is about what worked in New Orleans and what's working in Williamson now and what worked here as the country moved to the West, which was the frontier. And when this place was great, it was the Wild West. It was robber barons that were creating this place that we're in right now that were kind of exploring a new frontier and trying to create things that never had been created before. And there's at least some underlying thinking that Silicon Valley is a mature ecosystem now, companies are getting bid up or some of them are overvalued and we've lost that resilience of the frontier culture.

So there's another narrative about the hardest challenges in the world that I feel a lot of the current generation, I can see it in our demographics at Ben & Jerry's as a board member. In terms of millennial demographics, people oriented towards purpose, solving the hardest challenges in the world is what we ask Google, Cisco, Salesforce, other companies that have sort of stepped up to the occasion because their programmers are working on tasks to improve the efficiency slightly of different companies and in a non-proximal way.

So the other story to me is what does it mean to go back to home and transform the place that you came to so there's opportunity? And to bring your colleagues along in an experience of understanding the culture at the local bar or the understanding of what it's like to go to a church or a synagogue or a temple on Sunday, or to go to a Friday night football game, or hear a banjo player kind of describe the history of music. These are experiences that I think this area of the country is thirsty for, but they can't find in the surreal bubble that they're looking for.

So whenever we bring people to Williamson, they leave saying, "This was the greatest experience of my life and I didn't even know that it was going to be because I feel connected to a community and I see the way people have dinner together, and families connect, and other things."

So I think that that's at the heart of what we do as ... heart of what Free Range does and its incredible ability to tell stories. And I know there are books that will come out soon that are a lot about that particular narrative changing and how we can make better decisions. I just think it's the stories that we tell ourselves ultimately that enable these ideas to work or not.

[00:53:13]

Randall Ussery: Yeah. If you were to actually speak with boomerangs there, individuals that have come back and they're spending time on the ground, a lot of the conversation typically is around, "I could spend 40 to 50 hours a week working for a company that doesn't have the values of Williamson's community or I could spent 40 to 50 hours a week solving problems of a place that has values I believe in." And so there's a particular longing to be part of the community, right, and be part of a value system that's going to, in essence, not necessarily change the world. I mean, you're not going to particularly ... You may not create the next Google, you may not be part of creating the next Google, but you can have a lot of impact in a very short period of time and set yourself up for life in many respects, right, and really be your own boss. There's a lot of autonomy, there's a lot of independence that comes with going to a place like Williamson.

Daryn Dodson: Yeah. And I don't know that I can see that it won't create the next Google...

Randall Ussery: Oh, yeah, yeah.

Daryn Dodson: But I agree, I think you're right on the boomerang thesis. I'm never surprised when people that are building ... And part of what we do is we bring some of the fastest growing companies in the world to Williamson that are from the portfolios of companies that we invest in and we invite them to come and they leave with different ideas than they had before and they build smarter and better. Now, how does Williamson benefit from that is a really important question to ask and that's about keeping capital within the community, creating kind of net income for the community, and that's still a problem that we're working on solving.

But I do think that there are people that are there that will come up with great solutions 'cause one of the great solutions we're looking for right now is how, in a world that AI is coming to, how rural communities continue to survive. Now what's that worth to rural communities around the world? It's worth a lot of money. You

solve diabetes and you come up with a patentable process to reduce A1C and parallel without using drugs. Those are very, very big ideas and part of the reasons why those kids in New Orleans are listening to the entrepreneurs' pitch and walking up and down the street and then betting on the ones they believe in is because they're developing a way of thinking that could build a significant decisive company for the future of their community.

[00:56:02]

Speaker 9: So I'm just wondering about a lot of the stuff you guys are talking about is so broad and long term and I'm just wondering about what sorts of data points and metrics you guys use to even understand how to orient yourself in terms of the decisions that are being made, the things that you're listening to to assess whether a strategy is on the right track, and whether there are things that you're missing, and things that need to be changed in the course of such an ambitious and far reaching program. How do you measure it, what do you measure, how do you make decisions midway through?

Dino Beckett: Well, from the health standpoint, we do have data points that are giving us the information that we need and that's kind of what's helped us have success so that we've had investment in many of our programs because of the data that we've been able to collect and show that the model that we have has been effective. There are other things that we've done that have not been so successful, but the majority of programs that we've done, just by having the iterations and having the team in place to go through that data and see how ... And also involving particular patient care, how patients are responding to that and being a part of that input to help us determine what are going to be the type of delivery mechanism that's going to be accepted by them to where we can take that and measure it, but then show how that component of what input they've been able to give us is also helping create results.

So we have ... Through electronic health records, we've been able to track a lot of the data points also through various lab results that we've been able to do. But then also, the biggest thing is that we've been able to show to CMS and Medicare services, we've been able to show bottom line that we're saving lots of money for them, so that's the biggest metric that everybody pays attention to. So when you have reduction in hospital admissions, ER visits, which if we can keep

a patient from going to a hospital emergency room, that's on average about $9,000. If we can stop them from ... I mean, if they obviously need care, they're going to, but a lot of times it's like, "You know, I've got a headache. I'm going to go to the emergency room." And that's a generalization, but a lot of times, some of that thought process is that way, but we start empowering them to be like, "What am I doing that could help prevent this, but then also being a part of being a better steward of what's going on?"

The other part of it is when you start allowing them to have communication and they build that trust in you, then they pick up the phone and say, "Hey, I'm not feeling well today. I think this is going on or that's going on." So they're communicating with you and they're telling you more about themselves and they're learning more about themselves. So in return, what happens is they understand that there are things that they could be doing to really impact their disease state. And like I said, we have very good data, we have very shared cost savings that we've been able exhibit through that as well.

[00:59:23]

Randall Ussery: Do we have any more questions? This will be the last one and then we'll wrap up so Daryn can eat.

Speaker 10: I think it's inspiring to hear about what you're doing on a microcosmic level and I also hear that the desire to extrapolate into fixing the world, I guess is what would be a way of thinking of it. How much or how good or how bad ... How much will it have to change our basic system of what I'll call capitalism? Is that helping or is that hindering us as a human group on Earth to advance our social welfare? How much will it have to change or how much is it a good lever?

Daryn Dodson: Well, it's a fundamental question, right. I'll take a shot at it, which is ... And I'll tell you, so I don't think it has to change very much is my option. And the way that I got there is trying to change it because I basically spent the first part of my career passing laws to protect low income people from predatory loans and I realized that, although we passed lots of laws and saved low income people billions of dollars in predatory fees, that I saw the leaders of companies act in ways that I was really not excited about, which is why I went to business school to study how people build companies differently.

But what I realize is it's not only about policy, 'cause companies are, of course, incredibly influential in creating policy, and it's not only about the behaviors, but it's about the hearts and minds of people too. And I think that if you can work with leaders to change their philosophy within a system and then you can put that in place in different corporate structures, then you can also create a lot of change. I'll try to be more specific.

So at Ben & Jerry's, we have 92 legally binding provisions that enable us to do some very unique things as a board in order to steward this social mission of the company. And the idea and the intention is to steward the social mission of the company, but it's regulating principles within that structure that create the possibility of doing that, not necessarily an outside regulatory force outside of the company. So I believe part of impact investing is a belief that you can create and demonstrate that companies can be built in ways that honor the natural resources in the world, that honor the communities that they're doing business within, that create ways to reduce bias and structural racism and gender biases within the structures, and that we can model out and demonstrate a way for the future of work to happen in a more equitable and aligned way.

So that's my really quick kind of thought about a reaction.

Randall Ussery: And what's interesting in that is Ben & Jerry's is bought by Unilever and then they're starting to use that as a north star for some of their practices, the way that Ben & Jerry's operates.

Daryn Dodson: That's right, yeah.

Randall Ussery: So you have this behemoth company now taking on best practices from Ben & Jerry's because of these provisions that have been put in place.

Speaker 10: And that will become, at some point, a prevailing culture?

Daryn Dodson: Well, for us optimists, it's an answer ... I guess I would say that's why I do what I do is that I'm building, along with a lot of my colleagues, a sector that's exponentially growing to demonstrate how things could be if we chose to not only push the rules that we have all the way to the limit, but create our own set of rules that honor these other parts of the planet and people and help to solve inequities and sort of build pathways out of poverty for communities.

I mean, I think eventually we want to be on a planet ... We invested in SpaceX recently, so I don't want to have to get on a rocket ship to go to another planet, we think in seven generations within native communities. I don't think people ... If we don't have demonstrations of other possible ways of creating a capitalistic but aligned strategy on creating a place where we can all live together in ways that have peace and are beyond famine and solving really, really difficult problems in the world, then we don't really have a whole bunch of other options. So demonstrating this is my way of answering your question.

Randall Ussery: A is for activist. Thanks guys, thanks for everyone.